

Ch 5 — Outcomes of Democracy

Accountability · Economic Growth · Equality · Dignity · Social Diversity

1. HOW DO WE ASSESS DEMOCRACY?

Evaluating democracy requires looking at its **outcomes** — what it actually delivers to citizens — not just its procedures.



Political

Free elections, civil liberties, rule of law, accountability



Economic

Growth, equality, poverty reduction, fair distribution



Social

Dignity, freedom, accommodation of diversity

The Expectation Gap: Citizens often expect democracy to deliver more than it does in reality — rapid economic growth, complete equality, social harmony. Democracies frequently fall short of these ideals, which is one reason public satisfaction with democracy is often low even in functioning democracies.

2. ACCOUNTABLE, RESPONSIVE, AND LEGITIMATE GOVERNMENT

A. Accountable Government

- Democracy ensures regular **elections** — citizens can vote out governments that underperform.
- **Right to Information (RTI Act, 2005)** — citizens can demand transparency from the government.
- An independent **judiciary** checks government action.
- A **free press** exposes corruption and misuse of power.

NCERT Observation: Democracy is better placed than alternatives to produce accountable government, but in practice it often falls short — corruption remains high, RTI is under-used, and many officials escape accountability.

B. Responsive Government

- Democracies respond to citizens' needs through the electoral process — parties that ignore voters lose power.
- Decision-making is **slower** due to debate, consultation, and the need to build consensus — but this creates more durable, widely-accepted decisions.
- **India example:** MGNREGA (2005) — the world's largest employment guarantee scheme — created in response to rural poverty. Shows responsiveness, but poverty remains: India still has hundreds of millions in poverty.

NCERT Observation: Democratic governments are more responsive than non-democratic ones in the long run, but their responsiveness is uneven — powerful groups get more attention than the marginalised.

C. Legitimate Government

- Legitimacy means the right to rule — citizens *accept* government authority.
- In democracy, legitimacy is derived from the **consent of the governed** through free and fair elections.
- The **right to dissent** (protests, strikes, petitions) is protected — paradoxically, this strengthens legitimacy by allowing grievances to be heard without overthrowing the system.
- Non-democracies rule by force or tradition — their legitimacy is fragile and depends on continued success.

3. ECONOMIC GROWTH AND DEVELOPMENT

Key Finding: Research comparing democratic and non-democratic countries over decades shows **no definitive link** between democracy and higher economic growth rates.

Dictatorships — faster short-term growth?

- China — authoritarian, very high GDP growth (8–10% for decades).
- Decision-making faster, no political opposition to delay projects.
- Can enforce unpopular but economically necessary policies.

Democracies — slower but more stable

- Growth is slower on average than some fast-growing dictatorships.
- But long-term stability is greater — fewer economic catastrophes.
- Poverty and famines more common under authoritarian rule.

- **No Guarantee:** Democracy does not guarantee high growth, nor does dictatorship.
- **Long-Term Stability:** Democratic economies are less prone to sudden collapse.
- **Inequality:** Both democratic and non-democratic systems can produce high inequality.

4. REDUCTION OF INEQUALITY AND POVERTY

The Central Tension: Democracy is built on *political equality* (one person, one vote), but economic outcomes in democracies are often *deeply unequal*.

- In elections, every citizen has equal power regardless of wealth.
- But in economic life, the wealthy have much greater influence — they fund parties, employ workers, control media.
- **India:** India's top 1% own more wealth than the bottom 70% combined (NCERT data).
- Rather than narrowing, the **gap between rich and poor is widening** in most democracies, including India.
- Democratic governments struggle to redistribute wealth because powerful economic groups oppose redistribution measures.

NCERT Observation: A democratic system that is obsessed with electoral competition may not be able to address long-term economic inequalities effectively.

5. ACCOMMODATION OF SOCIAL DIVERSITY

Democracy is the best system for managing diverse, multi-cultural societies — through negotiation, protection of minority rights, and accommodation.

How Democracy Accommodates Diversity

- **Majority Rule with Minority Rights:** The majority governs, but the rights of minorities are protected by the constitution.
- **Negotiation rather than suppression:** Conflicts between groups are resolved through dialogue, elections, and law — not by force.
- Federalism, reservations, language policies, and cultural rights are tools democracies use to include diverse groups.

Belgium — SUCCESS

- Deep linguistic divide (Dutch/French/German speakers).
- Solved through power-sharing: linguistic community governments, equal cabinet representation.
- Remained united without civil war.

Sri Lanka — FAILURE

- Sinhala majority used democracy to marginalise Tamil minority.
- "Sinhala Only" language policy excluded Tamils from public life.
- Result: ethnic civil war lasting 26 years (1983–2009).

Key Insight: Democracy is not a guarantee of social harmony — it can be used by the majority to oppress minorities if constitutional safeguards are weak. Belgium succeeded; Sri Lanka failed.

6. DIGNITY AND FREEDOM

The **most significant outcome** of democracy is the **recognition of human dignity and individual freedom**.

Why dignity matters most: Economic development can occur under authoritarian regimes. Social harmony can be enforced by fear. But *equal dignity* — treating every citizen as an equal, regardless of gender, caste, religion, or class — is uniquely associated with democratic governance.

Women's Dignity

- The **73rd and 74th Constitutional Amendments** (Panchayati Raj) reserve one-third of seats in local government for women.
- This has brought millions of women into public life and decision-making.
- Democratic values support women's right to work, vote, and live free of violence.

Dignity of Marginalised Groups

- **Reservation for SC/ST and OBC** communities in education, government jobs, and legislative seats.
- Constitutional prohibition on untouchability (Article 17).
- Rights to organise, protest, and demand equality — tools that help marginalised groups fight discrimination.

Key Caveat: Dignity and freedom in democracy are *not automatic* — they require constant struggle. In India, caste discrimination, gender violence, and religious intolerance persist. Democracy provides the tools (law, courts, elections, protest) to fight for dignity — it does not deliver it automatically.

7. OVERALL ASSESSMENT — DEMOCRACY VS NON-DEMOCRACY

Feature	Democracy	Non-Democracy
Accountable Government	Yes — elections, RTI, free press keep rulers accountable	No — rulers are not answerable to citizens
Economic Growth	Moderate; long-term stable; no guarantee of high growth	Can be rapid (China) but prone to crashes; high risk
Equality	Political equality guaranteed; economic equality uneven	Often high inequality; no guarantee of fairness
Diversity	Better at accommodating diversity through negotiation	Often suppresses diversity by force
Dignity & Freedom	Best system for protecting individual rights and dignity	Rights often curtailed; freedom restricted

NCERT Conclusion: Democracy is not a perfect system, but it is better than alternatives at providing *accountable, legitimate, and responsive government*. It gives citizens the *right to complain and demand improvement* — which is itself a measure of its success.